

Reclaiming land outside the Freeport

*Testing a Budget 2026 promise about land reclamation in Malta
against satellite imagery, seabed and protected-area maps and research*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“The Government is preparing to launch a
large-scale land reclamation project
outside the Freeport perimeter next year.”***

Clyde Caruana, Minister for Finance, Budget Speech 2026, 27 October 2025.

In 2019: a seabed study found sites “possible and environmentally safe” (Environment Minister).

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Existing works confirmed; the new project and its safety not shown

Version 1.2 · 5 October 2026

Status: draft (right of reply: Finance, Environment ministries)

Prepared from public sources, Sentinel-2, EEA and EMODnet data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In the Budget 2026 speech on 27 October 2025, Finance Minister Clyde Caruana said: **“A reclamation project is already under way in the Freeport, and now it is time to take the next step. The Government is preparing to launch a large-scale land reclamation project outside the Freeport perimeter next year.”** The land would serve industry and maritime activity and let commercial activities move away from where families live. In 2019 the then Environment Minister said a seabed study had found “five or six sites where reclamation is possible and environmentally safe”. We tested what we could a year later.

- 1

The existing reclamation is real. Sentinel-2 shows about 3.7 ha (±1) of new land at Freeport Terminal 2, summer 2023 to 2026, close to the 30,000 m² the Freeport Corporation describes.
- 2

The large-scale project has no public detail. Neither the speech nor the Prime Minister gave a site, size, cost, fill source or timetable. We found no project description, environmental screening, planning application or call for it by 3 October 2026.
- 3

The environmental basis is unpublished. The EUR 11 million seabed study, said in 2019 to identify five or six “environmentally safe” sites and to go to public consultation, has not been published. Budget lines for reclamation fell from EUR 500,000 (2023) to EUR 10,000 (2025).
- 4

The area is close to protected sites and mapped seagrass. Three Natura 2000 designations lie within about 0.5 km of the new land; older maps show Posidonia meadows 0.2 km away. Malta reports its Posidonia beds overall as favourable; the 34% loss often cited is Mediterranean-wide.
- 5

Verdict: not substantiated (moderate confidence). The statement is a plan, and its first sentence is accurate. But the 2019 assurance that the sites are “possible and environmentally safe”, and the benefits for families, rest on documents that have not been shown.



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1

The claim and what we could verify

The main claim is in the English text of the Budget Speech 2026 [1], which we read in full on the Ministry for Finance website. The Prime Minister expanded on it at a press conference after the Budget, as quoted by Lovin Malta on 28 October 2025 [2]. The environmental claim dates from 2019, when the then Environment Minister said a seabed study had identified sites where reclamation was “possible and environmentally safe” [3].

What was said	Who	Access
“A reclamation project is already under way in the Freeport, and now it is time to take the next step.”	Finance Minister [1]	Read in full
“The Government is preparing to launch a large-scale land reclamation project outside the Freeport perimeter next year.” Industrial and maritime use; relocation of “certain commercial activities” so spaces can be “enjoyed by our families”.	Finance Minister [1]	Read in full
“The sea near the Freeport is an ideal depth for these kinds of projects, and our idea is to relocate industries that bother people.”	Prime Minister [2]	Read in full
“There are five or six sites where reclamation is possible and environmentally safe.”	Environment Minister, 2019 [3]	Read in full

SCOPE NOTE
This check does not judge whether Malta should reclaim land. It asks whether the statements are backed by evidence that has been shown. Absence of a document in our searches is not proof that it does not exist; we list what we are asking for.

2

Method

Questions. (1) Is a reclamation under way at the Freeport? (2) Has the large-scale project been launched or described? (3) Is there shown evidence that the sites are “possible and environmentally safe”, as said in 2019?

Evidence. Sentinel-2 satellite imagery over Terminal 2, summers 2017–2026: for each summer, the per-pixel median of eight clear scenes, with land where the water index (NDWI) is below zero [8]. Natura 2000 boundaries from the European Environment Agency [7]. Freeport operator statements [5, 6]; a press analysis of budget allocations [4]; peer-reviewed seagrass studies [9, 10]. New in version 1.2: seagrass maps from UNEP-WCMC [12] (whose licence does not allow us to redistribute the polygons, so we keep only derived figures) and EMODnet Seabed Habitats [13]; sea depth from EMODnet Bathymetry [14]; and Malta’s own assessment of its Posidonia beds under Article 17 of the Habitats Directive [15]. Scripts: *tools/cc-017-report/*; data: *data/cc-017/*.

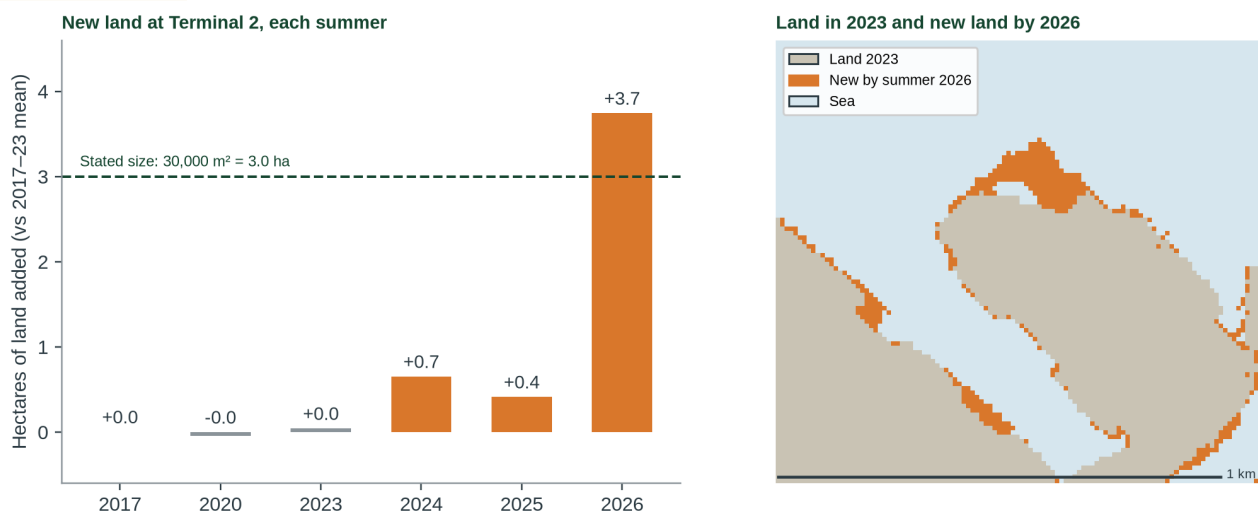
Grades. Direct satellite measurement and peer-reviewed observational studies are grade B; official statements, statistics and reviews grade C. ♦ marks a source known second-hand.

3 What the research says

Posidonia oceanica meadows, a priority habitat under the EU Habitats Directive, have lost an estimated 34% of their known area across the Mediterranean in fifty years, mainly through the combined effect of local pressures [9]. A critical review lists coastal development, dredging and dumping among the main human causes [10]. Land reclamation combines all three: the footprint is lost and the fill and sediment plume can smother nearby beds. This is why the location and a habitat survey decide whether a site is “environmentally safe”; the claim cannot be judged without them.

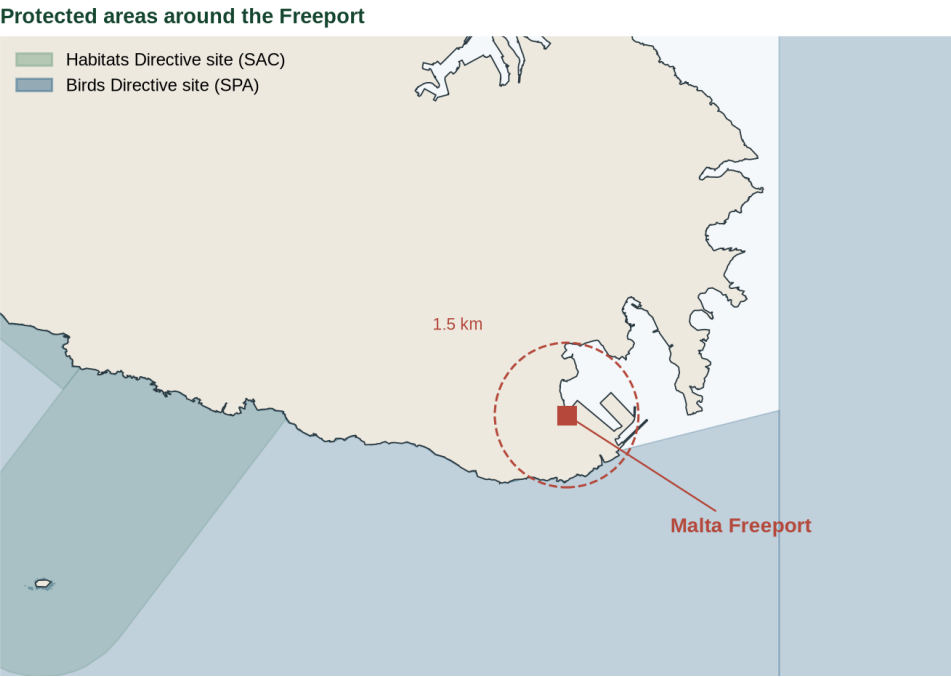
The 34% figure is for the whole Mediterranean, not for Malta. Malta’s own reports to the EU assess its *Posidonia* beds as favourable overall in both 2013–2018 and 2019–2024: 68.46 km² of meadow, from a complete survey in 2018–2019, of which 2.08 km² was not in good condition, with a stable trend [15]. That is a national assessment; it does not report the meadows of any one bay, and it does not test a new project.

4 What the data show



Per-pixel median of eight clear Sentinel-2 scenes each summer (May–Oct); land = NDWI < 0; 10 m pixels; about ±1 ha. Isolated specks are moored ships and wave glint.

Figure 1. Land at Freeport Terminal 2 from Sentinel-2. No change 2017–2023; new land from 2024, about 3.7 ha by summer 2026, close to the stated 30,000 m² [5, 6].



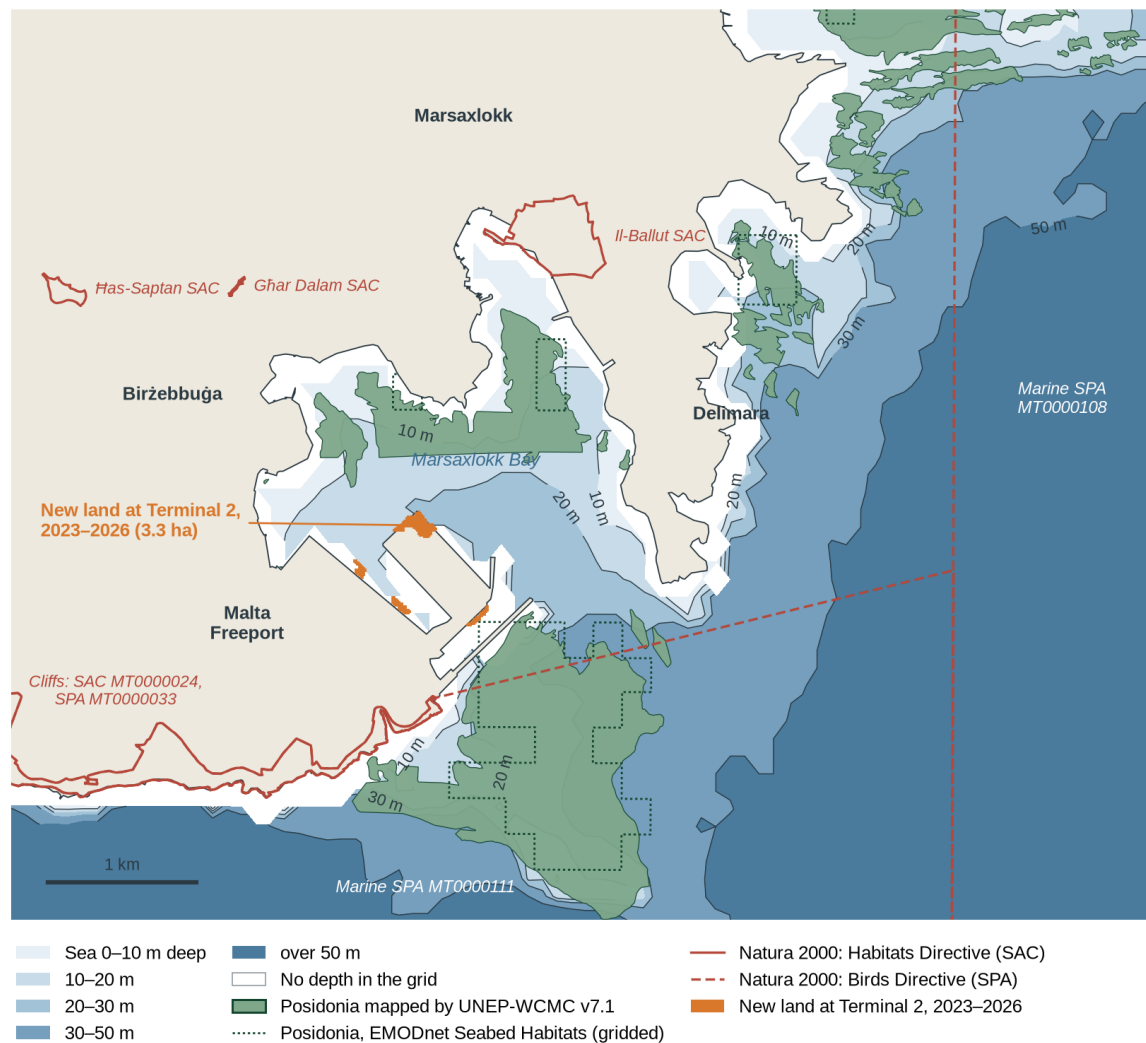
Sources: EEA Natura 2000 (2024 release); coastline © OpenStreetMap contributors.

Figure 2. Natura 2000 sites around the Freeport. The square marks the reference point used in version 1.0, on the shore west of Terminal 2; the dashed circle around it is 1.5 km. The marine bird area MT0000111 (Żona fil-Baħar fil-Lbiċ) begins about 1.1 km south of that point and about 0.4 km south of the new land at Terminal 2 [7].

Indicator	Value	Source	Grade
New land at Terminal 2, 2023 → 2026	+3.7 ha (±1)	Sentinel-2 [8]	B
Stated reclamation at Terminal 2	~30,000 m²; ~1 Mt fill	Freeport Corporation [5]	C
Natura 2000 designations within 1.5 km	3 (two overlap on the same cliffs)	EEA [7]	C
Marine SPA MT0000111: distance; area	0.4 km; 256 km²	EEA [7]	C
Cliff SAC MT0000024 and SPA MT0000033	0.5 km	EEA [7]	C
Mapped Posidonia: nearest to the new land; within 1 km	0.2 km; 120 ha	UNEP-WCMC [12]	C
Mapped Posidonia within 1 km (gridded layer)	72 ha	EMODnet [13]	C
Sea depth within 1 km of the new land (10th–90th pct.)	5–30 m (median 18 m)	EMODnet [14]	B
Depth of mapped meadows in the bay (10th–90th pct.)	8–34 m (median 19 m)	EMODnet [12, 14]	B
Malta’s Posidonia beds, overall (2013–18; 2019–24)	Favourable; favourable, stable	Article 17 [15]	C
Reclamation budget 2023 / 2024 / 2025	EUR 500k / 100k / 10k	MaltaToday analysis ♦ [4]	C
Seabed study published	No	Searches, 3 Oct 2026	–
Project description, screening or call for the new project	None found	Searches, 3 Oct 2026	–

All values in data/cc-017/checks.csv and bay_stats.csv. Distances are the shortest distance from the new land at Terminal 2 (Sentinel-2, 2023–2026) to each site boundary; from the edge of the 1.0 × 1.1 km Terminal 2 window they are 0.3 and 0.4 km (data/cc-017/natura2000_distances.csv). The site of the planned project is not known. MT0000033 lies almost wholly inside MT0000024.

Marsaxlokk Bay: sea depth, mapped seagrass and protected sites around the Freeport



Within 1 km of the new land the sea is mostly 5–30 m deep (median 18 m), with 120 ha of mapped Posidonia; the nearest mapped meadow is 0.2 km away.

Seagrass: UNEP-WCMC, Short F.T. (2021), Global Distribution of Seagrasses v7.1, www.unep-wcmc.org (survey dates 1961–2014; not redistributed); EMODnet Seabed Habitats (2025).
Depth: EMODnet Bathymetry DTM 2024 (cells of about 100 m). Natura 2000: EEA (2024). New land: Copernicus Sentinel-2. Coastline © OpenStreetMap contributors.

Figure 3. Marsaxlokk Bay. Sea depth from EMODnet (cells of about 100 m; near parts of the shore the grid has no depth); Posidonia meadows as mapped by UNEP-WCMC from surveys dated 1961–2014 [12] and, as a gridded outline, by EMODnet [13]; Natura 2000 sites [7]; new land at Terminal 2 [8]. The Prime Minister said the sea near the Freeport is “an ideal depth for these kinds of projects” [2]; the map shows the depths without judging which depth is ideal.

5

Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Is the next step under way?		NOT VISIBLE
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION The government has repeated the plan at the highest level, and a smaller reclamation is being built at the same port, so the capability and intent exist.	EVIDENCE AGAINST A year after the speech, no site, size, cost, fill source, environmental screening or call has been made public. Similar announcements since 2005 were not delivered outside ports [4].	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the launch “next year” is not yet shown.		
Q2 Are the sites “environmentally safe”?		NOT SHOWN
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION A seabed study costing EUR 11 million exists, and ERA's draft is reported to have aimed to avoid Posidonia and protected areas [4]. Malta reports its Posidonia beds overall as favourable and stable [15].	EVIDENCE AGAINST The study has not been published or consulted on, seven years after it was promised for consultation [3]. The new land at Terminal 2 lies about 0.4 km from a marine Natura 2000 site and 0.5 km from protected cliffs [7]; mapped meadows lie 0.2 km away, with about 120 ha within 1 km [12].	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the environmental assurance rests on a document that has not been shown.		
Q3 Will families gain space?		UNSPECIFIED
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION Moving noisy or heavy industry away from homes could free land and reduce nuisance.	EVIDENCE AGAINST Which activities would move, and which spaces would be freed, has not been said.	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the benefit cannot be tested yet.		

6

Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. A reclamation project is already under way in the Freeport	About 3.7 ha of new land at Terminal 2 since 2023 [8], as stated [5, 6].	SUPPORTED
B. A large-scale project outside the perimeter will be launched in 2026	No public step found by 3 Oct 2026; no site or size given.	NOT SHOWN
C. “There are five or six sites where reclamation is possible and environmentally safe” (2019)	Seabed study unpublished; a marine Natura 2000 site lies ~0.4 km and mapped Posidonia ~0.2 km from the Terminal 2 works [7, 12].	NOT SHOWN
D. Commercial activity will move so families can enjoy the space	Activities and spaces not identified.	NOT SHOWN
E. “The sea near the Freeport is an ideal depth for these kinds of projects” (Prime Minister)	Within 1 km of the Terminal 2 works the sea is mostly 5–30 m deep [14]; “ideal” is not defined. Mapped meadows in the bay lie at similar depths, 8–34 m [12].	NOT TESTED

7

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Accurate about the existing works; the new project and its environmental assurance have not been shown. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) The first sentence checks out: land is being reclaimed at the Freeport. (2) The large-scale project is described only by purpose; nothing public lets anyone check its size, site or effects. (3) The 2019 statement that the sites are “possible and environmentally safe” depends on a study that has not been published, in an area close to protected sites. A plan stated more strongly than the evidence offered is what our scale calls *Not substantiated*; it may prove sound once the documents are shown.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The ERA seabed / land reclamation study, with its site list, habitat maps and method.
- ☐ The site, area, fill source and timetable of the project outside the Freeport.
- ☐ Any environmental screening, strategic environmental assessment or habitat survey for it.
- ☐ The 2018–2019 national Posidonia survey reported to the EU, as a map of Marsaxlokk Bay (we did not find it published).
- ☐ Which commercial activities would move, and which spaces would be freed for families.

8

Limitations

- Searches cannot prove a negative: a step may have been taken without public record.
- Satellite land areas are accurate to about ± 1 ha (shoreline pixels, moored ships, glint).
- The seagrass maps compile older surveys (1961–2014 and 2002; EMODnet’s Maltese layer is gridded at about 230 m). They show where meadows were mapped, not their condition now; nearness to meadows or Natura 2000 sites is not by itself evidence of harm.
- EMODnet depth cells are about 100 m across; near the shore and in parts of the inner harbour the grid has no depth.

- We tried a bay-wide Sentinel-2 check for new land outside Terminal 2 (MNDWI, green and SWIR bands). It was not robust: over open water the index changed sign between scenes, giving tens of hectares of false change in control years, so it is not used (*tools/cc-017-report/s2_bay.py*).
- Budget allocations are known through a press analysis ♦.
- Peer-reviewed papers were read as abstracts.

References

- [1] Caruana C. (27 Oct 2025). Budget Speech 2026, pp. 52–53. Ministry for Finance.
<https://finance.gov.mt/wp-content/uploads/2025/11/Budget-Speech-2026.pdf>
- [2] Diacono T., Lovin Malta (28 Oct 2025). ‘Game changer’: Robert Abela discusses land reclamation plans off coast of Birżebbuġa. (Read in full, 5 Oct 2026.)
<https://lovinmalta.com/news/watch-game-changer-robert-abela-discusses-land-reclamation-plans-off-cost-of-birzebbuga/>
- [3] MaltaToday (Sep 2019). Land reclamation decision informed by EUR 11 million seabed study.
https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/98630/land_reclamation_decision_informed_by_11_million_seabed_study
- [4] MaltaToday (15 Apr 2025). The land reclamation saga: a never-ending story. ♦
https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/national/134510/analysis__the_land_reclamation_saga_a_neverending_story
- [5] Malta Freeport Corporation (2026). Squaring-off project: visit by the Prime Minister and Cabinet ministers.
<https://maltafreeport.gov.mt/uncategorized/squaring-off-project-visit-by-the-prime-minister-and-cabinet-ministers/News>
- [6] Malta Freeport Terminals (5 Sep 2025). Prime Minister visits Freeport as ambitious Terminal 2 expansion gathers pace.
<https://maltafreeport.com.mt/news/prime-minister-visits-freeport-as-ambitious-terminal-2-expansion-gathers-pace/>
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<https://bio.discomap.eea.europa.eu/arcgis/rest/services/ProtectedSites/Natura2000Sites/MapServer>
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- [10] Boudouresque C.-F., Bernard G., Pergent G., Shili A., Verlaque M. (2009). Regression of Mediterranean seagrasses caused by natural processes and anthropogenic disturbances and stress: a critical review. *Botanica Marina* 52(5):395–418. doi:10.1515/BOT.2009.057. (Abstract read.) <https://doi.org/10.1515/BOT.2009.057>
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- [12] UNEP-WCMC, Short F.T. (2021). Global Distribution of Seagrasses, version 7.1. UN Environment Programme World Conservation Monitoring Centre. doi:10.34892/x6r3-d211. Queried 5 Oct 2026 (www.unep-wcmc.org); UNEP-WCMC General Data License: shown here as a map, not redistributed. <https://doi.org/10.34892/x6r3-d211>
- [13] EMODnet Seabed Habitats (2025). Seagrass cover (Essential Ocean Variable) in Europe and the Caribbean, version 2025. CC BY 4.0. Maltese polygons from map EUSM16me (2016); the source field names the Malta Environment and Planning Authority for some of them and is blank for those in this bay.
<https://emodnet.ec.europa.eu/geonetwork/srv/eng/catalog.search#/metadata/39746d9c-4220-425c-bc26-7cb3056c36a5>
- [14] EMODnet Bathymetry Consortium (2024). EMODnet Digital Bathymetry (DTM 2024). doi:10.12770/cf51df64-56f9-4a99-b1aa-36b8d7b743a1. Via the EMODnet WCS, 5 Oct 2026.
<https://doi.org/10.12770/cf51df64-56f9-4a99-b1aa-36b8d7b743a1>
- [15] European Environment Agency. Article 17 web tool: habitat 1120 *Posidonia* beds, Malta (Mediterranean marine region), periods 2013–2018 and 2019–2024; read 5 Oct 2026.
<https://nature-art17.eionet.europa.eu/article17/habitat/summary/?period=6&subject=1120>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient, or direct measurement · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	3 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply to the Ministry for Finance and the Ministry for the Environment not yet sent.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections. (1) The 2019 statement is quoted as said: “least environmental damage” (a paraphrase) → “possible and environmentally safe” (cover, TL;DR, sections 2, 3, 5, 6 and 7); sub-claim C now tests that wording. (2) Distance to Natura 2000: “about 1 km from the Freeport”, measured from an onshore point west of Terminal 2 → 0.4 km from the new land at Terminal 2 to the marine SPA MT0000111 and 0.5 km to the cliff sites (shortest distance to the EEA boundaries; <i>data/cc-017/natura2000_distances.csv</i>); tile “1 km” → “0.4 km”. (3) “Three Natura 2000 sites” → three designations, two of which (SAC MT0000024, SPA MT0000033) overlap on the same cliffs. (4) Flyer: right of reply now names the Finance and Environment ministries, as the report does; the –34% seagrass loss is labelled Mediterranean-wide. Verdict and confidence unchanged.
1.2	5 Oct 2026	Upgrade. (1) New Figure 3: a map of Marsaxlokk Bay with sea depth (EMODnet), Posidonia meadows as mapped by UNEP-WCMC and EMODnet, full-resolution Natura 2000 boundaries and the new land at Terminal 2. Mapped meadows lie 0.2 km from the new land, about 120 ha within 1 km, where the sea is mostly 5–30 m deep. (2) Fairness: Malta’s Article 17 reports assess its Posidonia beds as favourable overall (2013–2018; 2019–2024, stable); the –34% loss is Mediterranean-wide (section 3, Q2, TL;DR, flyer). (3) The Prime Minister’s words are now quoted in full from Lovin Malta, and tested as sub-claim E (not tested: “ideal” is not defined). (4) Tile “0.4 km” → “120 ha” of mapped Posidonia (the 0.4 km stays in the text). (5) A bay-wide Sentinel-2 check for other new land was tried and dropped as not robust (limitations). Verdict and confidence unchanged.